What You Can Build with the Google Civic Information API

Capabilities, available data, limitations, and app ideas for a US voting web app. Prepared November 2026.

1. Summary

The Google Civic Information API is free and needs only an API key. Its main job is to tell a US voter **where, when and on what they vote**, based on their registered home address. Google shut down the Representatives (elected officials) lookup on **April 30, 2025**. Many older tutorials still use it, so an app built today should not depend on this API for "find my representatives".

2. Endpoints available today

Base URL: `https://www.googleapis.com/civicinfo/v2`. Every call takes `?key=YOUR_API_KEY`. No user login (OAuth) is required.

Endpoint	What it does
GET /elections	Lists the elections that currently have data: ID, name and election day.
GET /voterinfo	The main endpoint. Takes a registered *address* (required). Optional: *electionId*, and *officialOnly=true* to limit results to official state sources. Returns polling places, ballot contents and election official details.
GET /divisions	Searches political areas (states, counties, districts, cities) by name or OCD-ID. Supports Lucene-style query syntax.
divisionByAddress	Added as the replacement for the officials lookup. Converts an address into the list of OCD-IDs for every district the address falls in.

3. Data you can get from voterinfo

Category	Fields returned
Polling places	Election-day locations: address, opening hours, notes, latitude/longitude, and the data source.
Early voting sites	Same as polling places, plus site name, start date and end date.
Drop-off locations	Places to return a completed ballot, with dates and hours.
Mail-only flag	*mailOnly*: whether the voter's precinct votes only by mail.
Contests (races)	Office, level (federal, state, county, city, school board, judicial), district, type (general, primary, run-off, referendum), number of seats, ballot placement.
Candidates	Name, party, order on the ballot, website, phone, email, photo URL, social media channels.
Referendums / measures	Title, subtitle, summary, full text, pro and con statements, vote needed to pass, effect of abstaining, possible responses.
Election offices	State and local: links to register, check registration, absentee info, polling place finder, ballot info and election rules; office hours, addresses, named officials with phone and email.
Sources	Each item lists where it came from and whether the source is official.
Other elections	*otherElections*: other elections that also have data for this address.

4. Limitations to plan around

- **US only.** Lookups are by registered address.
- **Data depends on the election calendar.** Polling places and ballot contents appear only as an election gets close. Between elections, voterinfo returns little or nothing unless an electionId is passed. Use the test election (`electionId=2000`) during development.
- **Coverage varies** by state and county, especially for local races and candidate details.
- **Two elections on the same day** for one address: polling and contest data comes back only after a second call that names one electionId.
- **No elected officials.** For representatives, combine divisionByAddress with OpenStates (state legislators, free key), the Congress.gov API (federal members), or Cicero / BallotReady (commercial, fuller coverage).
- **Quotas and terms** are not listed on the reference pages. Check your key's quota in the Google Cloud Console, and keep the key on a server or restrict it to your domains.

5. App ideas

Ideas are ordered roughly by how well they fit the API's strengths. Effort is for a small team or a solo developer.

App	What it does	API features used	Effort
1. My Voting Plan	Enter an address and get a personal plan: polling place on a map, hours, early-vote and drop-off options, a checklist, and calendar reminders.	voterinfo (locations, mailOnly, election offices)	Low
2. Sample Ballot Explorer	See every race and measure on your ballot. Read candidate profiles and measure summaries, mark choices, and print a cheat sheet for the polls.	voterinfo (contests, candidates, referendums)	Medium
3. Ballot Measure Explainer	Shows each measure's pro and con statements side by side in plain language, with an optional AI summary of the full text.	voterinfo (referendum fields)	Medium
4. Registration & Deadline Helper	Sends users to their state's registration, registration check and absentee pages, with office contact details.	voterinfo (state and local election offices)	Low
5. Early-Vote & Drop-Box Finder	Mobile-friendly map of the nearest locations, with dates, hours and directions.	voterinfo (earlyVoteSites, dropOffLocations)	Low
6. Local Races Spotlight	Filters the ballot to school board, city council and judicial races, which voters know least about.	voterinfo (contests by level and role)	Medium
7. Who Represents Me	Address to districts to officials, with contact details.	divisionByAddress + OpenStates + Congress.gov	Medium-High
8. Organization Election Hub	An embeddable page that a school, employer or nonprofit can put on its own site for its community.	All of the above, white-labeled	Medium
9. Election Reminder Bot	SMS or email reminders: registration deadline, early voting opens, election day, with the voter's own polling place.	elections + voterinfo	Medium

Recommendation

Start with a combination of **#1 My Voting Plan** and **#2 Sample Ballot Explorer**. Both run off a single voterinfo call, use the richest part of the API, and give a voter something useful within seconds. Ideas #3, #4 and #9 make good follow-up features. A product requirements document for this combined app is provided separately.

6. Getting started

- Create a project in the Google Cloud Console and enable **Google Civic Information API**.

- Create an API key and restrict it (HTTP referrers, or IP addresses for a server).
- Try a test request:

```
curl "https://www.googleapis.com/civicinfo/v2/voterinfo?key=YOUR_KEY&address=340%20Main%20St%20Venice%20CA&electionId=2000"
```

7. Documentation

- API overview and reference: developers.google.com/civic-information/docs/v2
- Using the API (keys, examples): developers.google.com/civic-information/docs/using_api
- voterInfoQuery: developers.google.com/civic-information/docs/v2/elections/voterInfoQuery
- electionQuery: developers.google.com/civic-information/docs/v2/elections/electionQuery
- divisions.search: developers.google.com/civic-information/docs/v2/divisions/search
- divisionByAddress announcement: groups.google.com/g/google-civicinfo-api/c/eWoEc2tn8DA
- Representatives API shutdown notice: groups.google.com/g/google-civicinfo-api/c/9fwFn-dhktA